by their seniors but couldn't resist the Yatra's pull)! In short, the Yatra cut across political and ideological lines. But the challenge remains to collectivize them and prevent them from again falling back into familiar divisions. Already the Congress has lost a lot of the momentum that Rahul generated. Maybe he can become an instrument for this purpose, for which he will need a whole new set of people with him.

Perhaps Rahul Gandhi may yet be India's Prime Minister in the future. The mahaul (environment) created by the Bharat Jodo Yatra has definitely front-ended this question. Already many like-minded parties (presumably spurred on by the Yatra's slogan of 'Bharat Jodo') are coalescing together under a common platform named the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA). Maybe Rahul will play the role of a coordinator in this formation. There could be multiple permutations to the alliance, but the net impact of this long Yatra could re-establish the secular parties at the national level!

But Rahul Gandhi has a bigger role to play in India's politics. Having firmly established himself in people's hearts, he must now accept the challenge of charting an ideological path forward. He has done enough to expose the RSS–BJP. Now he must act. On the one hand, he must redress the mistakes made by privatization, liberalization and trickle-down politics. On the other hand, he *has to* tackle the RSS on the ground. Only he has the ideological commitment and sincerity to do this effectively, to once again walk the path that Mahatma Gandhi ji once walked.

Today, when India faces an undeclared emergency, when crony capitalism runs amuck and when inequalities have exploded, we need a champion to fight for socialism (which is an integral part of India's Constitution). Similarly, we need a champion to fight for the Right to Information Act, the Street Vendors Act, the Forest Rights Act, the new Land Acquisition Act, the Employment Guarantee Act, the PESA Act, etc. We need someone to connect and cooperate with people's movements, which fight every single day for civic rights and freedoms. And we need someone who will keep fighting, even if it means going to jail.